

## **I Concur, You Are Absolutely Correct that I am Correct: Agreement as an Argumentative Strategy**

**Sara K. Straub, Jeremie L. Beller, & Tim W. Hunt**  
*University of Oklahoma*

Traditional argumentation theory tells us that debates are most successful when opponents disagree, highlighting areas where one participant outshines the other (Kelley, 1962; Levassuer, & Dean, 1996). During the 2008 presidential debates, however, Senator Barack Obama initiated a debate technique that seemed to contradict accepted debate logic. He frequently agreed with his opponent, while creating substantial arguments. This study employs a discourse analysis of the debates between Senator Obama and Senator John McCain to identify the technique of agreement employed in the 2008 presidential debates. The applicability of agreement as an argument form in additional debate contexts is also explicated. Proven agreement types such as agreement for the common good (Lang, 1987), backhanded compliment (Benoit, 2007; Kelley, 1962), and agreement for the sake of being polite (Dailey, Hink, & Hink, 2005) are identified. Furthermore, three additional types of agreement in the form of an argument, including agreement as counter-contention, agreement as an expression of bi-partisanship, and agreement as a touting strategy are posited.

Debates provide a forum for contestants to distinguish positions while presenting the merits of their own position. Since disagreement is necessary for a debate to occur, statements of agreement seem counter-intuitive. Given the seemingly contradictory nature of agreeing during what is, by definition, a disagreement, argumentation scholars have wrestled philosophically with the role of agreement in debates. In the struggle over the legitimacy of agreement as a strategy in debate, two clear contentions have emerged. The first contention asserts that agreement in debate contradicts the purpose

and function of debate in general. The second contention acknowledges that agreement does occur in debate regardless of how nonsensical it may seem.

The paradoxical expression of agreement in debates became a topic of interest during the 2008 United States presidential debates between Senators Barack Obama and John McCain. In the first general election debate, Senator Obama often employed explicit statements of agreement with Senator McCain. The McCain campaign and its supporters noticed the surprising rhetoric and consequently created an entirely new marketing strategy. The McCain campaign aired advertisements across the nation exploiting Obama's statements of agreement. The message of the Republican campaign essentially stated, "Senator McCain is the best candidate to lead America and Senator Obama agrees." This marketing strategy reflected the traditional sense of argument which views language of disagreement as essential to debate and language of agreement as consent to defeat.

Scholars have noted the presence of agreement in presidential debate; however, extant research aimed at establishing a discernible technique for agreement within debate is limited. This study further investigates the form of agreement in a debate context, via the 2008 presidential debates. While the context and exemplar used for this study is in the political realm, this paper seeks to establish forms and/or structures of agreement as arguments that can be applied to debate in a broader, more generalized, context. Thus, this paper focuses on agreement and process rather than Presidents, politics, or content.

We compile in two ways techniques for using agreement within a debate. First, we identify three forms outlined in the current literature in order to establish the ways agreement usage has previously been

documented. We then conduct a discourse analysis of the 2008 presidential debates. Based on these findings, three additional forms of agreement as argument are posited. We also note the implications of these findings to debate settings beyond a political context. Finally, the limitations of this study and other areas of potential research are articulated.

### **Synthesizing Debate (Dis)Agreement**

Ehninger (1970) explains that an arguer is someone who is convinced another's beliefs are "invalid or pernicious" (p. 102). The arguer thus engages in an argument in order to "set [the other] party straight" (Ehninger, 1970, p. 102). In this sense, an argument involves at least two or more people who go through "a process... reason[ing] their way from one set of problematic ideas to the choice of another" (Brockriede, 1975, p. 180). A debate follows these same principles but places a higher value on critical thinking and evidential clashes in both support and opposition of a proposition (Freeley & Steinberg, 2009). The inclusion of critical thinking means arguments can occur not only about the reliability of the content of an argument (Moore & Parker, 2004) but in regards to the validity of the form (i.e., syllogism, Toulmin model, co-orientational model) as well (Inch, Warnick, & Endres, 2006). If both sides of an issue are critically debated before a general public audience, it is referred to as a "public debate forum" (Ziegelmüller & Kay, 1997, p. 218). Presidential debates have become one of the most watched public debate forums, allowing for the general citizenry to witness and critically analyze public argument (Goodnight, Majdik, & Kephart, 2009).

Americans first witnessed televised presidential debates in the 1960 contest between John F. Kennedy and Richard Nixon. Prior to the 1960 cycle, presidential

candidates debated in primaries, but the Kennedy-Nixon debates represented the first televised debates between presidential candidates in the general election. It was 16 years later before Americans witnessed another televised presidential debate. Since then, debates have become an expected part of presidential campaigns (Hellweg, Pfau, & Brydon, 1992). Between the 1960 and 2008 election cycles, 27 general election presidential debates have been televised, providing voters access to candidates and giving scholars fertile ground for research. Scholars have studied such areas as the ways candidates use reasoning, style, impact, cohesion, competence, and form (e.g., Benoit & Hansen, 2002; Holbert, Hansen, Caplan, & Mortensen, 2007; Jamieson & Birdsell, 1988; Pfau, 2002).

A number of scholars have questioned the legitimacy of labeling presidential debates as debates at all, calling them “joint press-conferences” (Lanoue & Schrott, 1991, p. 156), “counterfeit debates” (Bitzer & Reuter, 1980, p. i), or simply, “joint appearances” (Farah, 2004, p. 29). McKinney and Carlin (2004), however, suggest the obvious use of arguments in presidential debates make it natural that theories of argumentation and debate guide presidential debate studies. Kephart (2005) sees such criticism linked with the expectation that presidential debates function within a forensic model. He argues that presidential debates be considered as a form of deliberative debate which provides for “deliberation based in the exchange of arguments” in an attempt to deal with “reasoned disagreement in pluralistic societies” (p. 381). Kephart (2005) thus broadens the concept of debate to include defensible appeals made to everyone involved in the deliberative process.

The introduction of televised debates provided voters a new forum for viewing candidates. In his book, *Political Campaigning*, Kelley (1960) argues for rational campaigning which takes place when campaign

discussion provides voters with adequate information about policies, personalities, and issues. One way in which rational campaigning happens, according to Kelley (1960), is when candidate differences are exposed in a public forum. These forums provide candidates the opportunity to highlight disagreements with their opponent in such areas as personality, interest, affiliation, and policy commitment. For Kelley, “only these provide a basis for choice” (1960, p. 14).

Benoit’s functional theory of political campaign discourse echoes Kelley’s basic assumption (Benoit, 2007; Benoit, & Harthcok, 1999; Benoit, Pier, & Blaney, 1997). Benoit (2007) advocates for the comparative function of campaigns, in which candidates work to distinguish themselves from their opponents through campaign messages. In other words, it is imperative that candidates disagree with their opponents in order to create legitimate, clearly defined alternatives from which the voter can choose. Since the goal of a campaign is to win more votes, candidates must separate themselves from their opponents and provide reasons why voters should choose them over other candidates. Debate appears to be among the most effective forums for accomplishing this task. In debate, candidates are “required to disagree” (Levassuer, & Dean, 1996, p. 131). It is a form of “verbal combat” in which winners and losers are determined (Doerfel & Connaughton, 2009, p. 204).

Given the competitive nature of debate, expressions of agreement between candidates seem unusual and even counter-productive. Poggi, D’Errico, and Vincze (2011) define agreement as “a relation of identity, similarity, or congruence between the opinions of two or more persons” (p. 466). Agreement in a presidential debate could threaten to eliminate distinctions, deprive voters of a sense of choice, and create the

perception of capitulation (Doerfel & Connaughton, 2009). In discussing campaign rhetoric at large, Kelley acknowledges that agreement is not unusual in discussions of basic public policy goals, but he notes, “what is rare, is for them to admit that they agree” (1962, p. 359).

### **Forms of Agreement**

Despite the potential pitfalls and seemingly contradictory nature of agreement in debate contexts, candidates do tend to express agreement during debates. Kelley’s (1962) analysis of the 1960 campaign found more instances of agreement during the four debates between Nixon and Kennedy than in non-debate appearances (Kelley, 1962). Kelley identified three forms of agreement in the Kennedy-Nixon campaign process. First, candidates agreed when they could not oppose the common good. Second, agreement formed a backhanded compliment and lastly, agreement was used as a form of politeness.

**Common good.** Debaters rely on agreement to create an ideological foundation, the common good, in order to move the debate toward specific policy-making proposals. Lang (1987) suggests that candidates attempting to attract undecided voters should avoid dangerously controversial issues and inflammatory rhetoric, instead relying on agreement to argue for the common good. Sharing a stage makes it difficult for one candidate to portray himself/herself as the only one who truly cares about the common good of the country. Other forms of campaigning allow a candidate to portray his or her opponent as being less concerned with the issues facing the nation, but the prospect of “imminent rebuttal” in the debate context changes the equation (Ellsworth, 1960, p. 799).

Kelley (1962) and Lang (1987) implicitly suggest

that agreement in such cases is forced. How can a presidential candidate not agree with such overarching themes as security, prosperity, peace, and the wealth of the country he/she seeks to govern? If one candidate leads the way in presenting the issue, the opposing candidate is forced to agree. Once candidates acknowledge agreement, the debate can shift from the shared goals to the diverse means they propose for achieving these goals. By expressing agreement on transcendent ideals, candidates lay the groundwork for specific policy-making disagreement.

**Backhanded compliment.** A second form of agreement appears outside of the debate context. In observing Nixon's agreement language in other campaign contexts, Kelley (1962) notes what he called a "backhanded compliment" (p. 359). Normally, a compliment identifies a positive attribute of a person but a backhanded compliment points out a negative attribute albeit with a positive presentation. Kelley's notion of a backhanded compliment, when combined with Benoit's (e.g., 2007) functional theory of politics, allows for the form of a backhanded compliment to be identified: the structural process of acclamation-attack.

**Acclamation-attack.** Benoit's functional theory of politics states that an acclamation involves a candidate's self-appraisal in which he/she highlights his/her character or policy position as superior to that of his/her opponent (Benoit, 2007; Benoit & Harthcock, 1999; Benoit et al., 1997). With acclamation, candidates aim to make themselves more appealing than their opponent by emphasizing their stronger qualities (Benoit, 2007). An acclamation can involve a candidate speaking about his/her superior political track record, more effective policy concept, or better understanding of the nation's needs.

Attack, on the other hand, differs from acclamation

in terms of its focus (Benoit, 2007; Benoit & Harthcock, 1999). When an acclamation has a personal focus to it, it becomes an attack. Debates and political campaigns offer candidates the opportunity to question the personal qualifications and character of their opponent (Benoit, 2007). When agreement as acclamation language is spoken, it is thus entirely possible that a simple agreement could be a veiled attack.

Agreement in the form of a backhanded compliment (acclamation-attack) becomes a type of argument. Kelley (1962) provides an instance of Nixon incorporating the acclamation-attack technique during a campaign speech. For this backhanded compliment, Nixon pointed out that he and Kennedy agreed, but only after Kennedy changed his position. Instead of complimenting Kennedy (acclamation), Nixon creates a premise for attacking Kennedy. By accentuating Kennedy's agreement with him, Nixon is then able to highlight the stability and consistency of his own position while simultaneously attacking Kennedy's inability to initially make the right choice. In this scenario, agreement takes the form of an acclamation-attack structure as an argument for why Nixon is the superior candidate.

Benoit and Harthcock (1999) found a higher percentage of acclamations present in debates than either attack or defense. Additionally, Kelley described backhanded compliments as being present in the campaign process and not within the debates proper. However, we postulate the acclamation-attack form could take place within a debate. The form of the argument allows for an arguer to incorporate backhanded compliment in a debate since the structure is not dependent on a campaign specific context.

**Politeness.** A third documented form of agreement provides a civilizing influence on the overall campaign



(Lang, 1987). Whereas the majority of campaigning is spent exposing differences between the candidates and trying to disconnect voters from a candidate's opponent (Benoit, 2007), debates offer candidates the opportunity to appear more civil than his/her general campaign rhetoric. When asked during a debate in the 2008 campaign why the campaign had turned so negative, McCain suggested the problem could have been prevented had his opponent, Senator Barack Obama, accepted his request for more debates (Commission on Presidential Debates, 2008c).

Politeness theory supports the civility argument. Since presidential personality and personal perception plays a key role in voter preference (Pfau & Diedrich, 1993; Vancil & Pendell, 1984), there is risk associated with a candidate appearing too disagreeable (Jamieson & Birdsell, 1988). The ability to acknowledge similarities with an opponent is one element of politeness that improves a candidate's personal image (Dailey et al., 2005). By expressing agreement, candidates can appear to be polite, above the politics, and more concerned about the country than their own campaigns.

The backhanded compliment is the only form of the three uses of agreement found in current literature that can be seen as a type of argument. Common good and politeness are incorporated into debates and campaigns to improve perceptions of character value. It is our contention, however, that there is more at work than meets the eye when agreement occurs in a debate. When used as a form of argument, such as the backhanded compliment, agreement allows candidates to put a new face on old politics. Thus, we offer the following research question:

RQ: What additional argumentation forms of agreement are used in a debate, if any?

## Method

Our investigation of the types of argument through agreement language is based on a discourse analysis of the three 2008 presidential debates between Senators Barack Obama and John McCain. The debates spanned a time period of 20 days with intervals between the debates of 12 days and 8 days, respectively. The first presidential debate, held on September 26<sup>th</sup>, took place at the Ford Center on the campus of the University of Mississippi in Oxford. Jim Lehrer, executive anchor and editor of the *NewsHour* on PBS, served as moderator and asked the candidates questions. The second debate was held on October 7<sup>th</sup> on the campus of Belmont University in Nashville, Tennessee. Tom Brokaw, anchor of NBC News, served as moderator within a town hall format in which a small audience of undecided voters personally addressed questions to the candidates. The third presidential debate was held on October 15<sup>th</sup> at Hofstra University in Hempstead, New York. CBS News anchor Bob Schieffer served as moderator and asked the candidates questions.

We obtained written transcripts of the debates from The Commission of Presidential Debates official website ([www.debates.org](http://www.debates.org)). The discourse analysis of the transcripts followed a three-step coding process. The first level utilized instances of agreement within the debates. The second code level relied on the previously identified literature for argument type codes. A third and final coding utilized categories generated by the authors of this study.

### Code Level One

Basic terms/phrases indicating agreement defined the first code level. This research design emphasized explicit language of agreement rather than mere inferences; we looked for precise language in which

a presidential candidate articulated agreement with his opponent. Agreement is identified as a debater's expression of a shared view or premise with his opponent through repetition of his opponent's view as his own or explicit statement of agreement. We excluded agreement with the moderator or independent participants in the audience, as well as agreement with former Presidents, other world leaders, or members of the candidates' party. The analysis was confined to instances in which one candidate expressed explicit agreement with the opposing debater. We regarded as key terms such words as "agree," "right," "give credit," "no doubt," "it's true," "commend," and "support[ed]." These terms, along with other words and phrases (specified later for each debate), provided a base level code for isolating episodes of agreement that occurred during the three presidential debates of 2008.

### **Code Level Two**

We applied a second code level to the McCain/Obama presidential debates of 2008 using themes from existing literature on agreement as argument. These themes consisted of agreement as common good, backhanded compliment, and politeness. Three coders independently analyzed the instances of agreement identified in level one coding and categorized each as either common good, backhanded compliment, politeness, or other.

### **Code Level Three**

We applied a third level of coding to instances of agreement identified as "other" in code level two. Coders independently performed constant comparative analyses of these instances to compile new categories of argumentative forms using agreement language.

## **Results**

A superficial reading might not reveal anything

revolutionary about the use of statements of agreement in the 2008 Presidential debates. However, upon closer inspection, it became apparent that argumentative techniques were taking place in which agreement was being used as a type of argument.

### **Code Level One**

The first level of coding of the three presidential debates of 2008 identified 24 statements of agreement made by a debater to his opponent. These statements were the unit of analysis for the study. At least two coders agreed on the categorization of all instances of agreement within all three coding levels, providing intercoder reliability throughout ( $\kappa = .95$ ). The specific terms used to indicate agreement were relatively diverse. The first debate contained 11 statements of explicit agreement. The key terms: “right,” “as [opponent] mentioned,” “agree,” “give [opponent] great credit” (on topic previously mentioned by opponent), and “there’s no doubt” identified episodes of agreement. The recurrent term “right” identified eight of the 13 episodes with six of these eight prefaced by an adverb to form the phrase “absolutely right.” On two occasions, the term “agree” is used and on one occasion each “as [opponent] mentioned,” “give [opponent] credit,” and “there’s no doubt” is used.

The second debate contained five episodes of explicit agreement. The word “agree” and the phrase “it’s true” indicated agreement. Four episodes used the term “agree.” “It’s true” was used only once to indicate agreement.

The third debate contained eight statements of agreement. The following words or phrases indicated cases of agreement: “and I supported [the opposition],” “agree,” “we both want,” “I give you credit,” “sure,” “it’s true,” and “absolutely right.”

## **Code Level Two**

Results of the second coding level supported the types and occurrences of agreement drawn from extant literature. As projected by previous researchers, we found instances of agreement for the sake of the common good (two occasions) and agreement for the sake of politeness (four occasions). Backhanded compliment was not present in these debates. The absence of this particular argument type supports Kelley's (1962) assertion that backhanded compliment does not occur within the context of Presidential debates.

## **Code Level Three**

Current literature provided explanations for six of the 24 instances of agreement identified in the 2008 presidential debates. Code level three sought to thematically identify the form of the remaining 21 statements of agreement. Analysis of these statements led us to articulate three new structures for the way agreement forms a type of argument: (1) agreement as counter-contention (12 instances), (2) agreement as an expression of bi-partisanship (3 instances), and (3) agreement as touting (3 instances).

### **Analysis**

The majority of agreement found in the 2008 presidential debates was categorized outside the types outlined in current literature. The void between the abundance of agreement language present in the debates and the available literature describing agreement in debates suggests the need for new ways of describing the form of agreement in debates.

## **Literature Forms Supported**

The existing literature describes two types of agreement in debate rhetoric: agreement for the common

good and politeness. A third type of agreement has been noted in non-debate rhetoric which we expected to be present in the 2008 debates. First, Senator Obama used agreement to express his interest in providing for the common good of the people of the United States. Clearly, he would be hard pressed to disagree with Senator McCain's assertion that "budget cuts are a dire necessity" (Commission, 2008a, p. 12) or that America is "the greatest nation on Earth" (Commission, 2008b, p. 22). Instead, by agreeing with McCain that cutting government spending is needed to better the country, Obama could explain the advantages of his plan and compare it to McCain's budget reform policy. This finding verifies the assertions of Kelley (1962), Ellsworth (1960), and Lang (1987) that fundamental agreement to create a common ground allows differences between the real world policy-making tactics of each candidate to be the focus of the debate rather than values and metaphysical moral issues.

Second, scholars have described backhanded compliment as a form of agreement outside the context of debate (Benoit et al., 1997; Kelley, 1962). We suggested backhanded compliment could and would appear as an agreement type during the debates investigated. After completing our analysis, however, we discovered no instances of this form of agreement in the debate and the available literature was upheld. Neither candidate incorporated the backhanded compliment as a form of agreement at any time during the three debates. Further research outside the realm of these transcripts could still find backhanded compliment present in debate, but this study cannot provide evidence that backhanded compliment occurred in the Presidential debates of 2008.

Finally, existing literature asserts that agreement language can maintain a cordial, relaxed environment. For instance, after McCain introduces Vice Presidential

candidate Sarah Palin's track record of working with and supporting organizations who help people with special needs, Obama responds that he "thinks it's very commendable, the work she's done on behalf of special needs, I agree with that, John" (Commission, 2008c, p. 17). Agreement in this instance, as the literature explains, keeps a friendly, unimposing environment. The acceptance and acknowledgement of the positive aspects of Palin's support of those with special needs allows for an amicable debate moment.

### **New Agreement Forms**

In addition to verifying previous research on agreement, we identified three new types of agreement in the debate format. Thus, we answer our research question by concluding that agreement does exist in debate as a form of argument beyond those forms articulated in the current literature. A thematic analysis of the additional agreement statements found agreement as a type of argument in the form of a counter-contention, an expression of bi-partisanship, and as a touting strategy.

**Agreement as counter-contention.** Counter-contentions are used to attack an opponent's evidence/reasoning by demonstrating he/she has incorrectly and illogically applied information to a particular issue (Freeley & Steinberg, 2009). While it would seem that agreement and *counter-contention* are mutually exclusive, an inspection of Obama's technique proves otherwise. Ironically, Obama incorporated agreement into his argumentative offense against McCain, structurally and deceptively refuting McCain's arguments. Agreement was found as three different types of counter-contention: disassociation, blame turn, and rebuttal.

The first type of agreement counter-contention employed in the debate is a disassociation argument. In

an agreement-disassociation argument, one candidate agrees with his opponent about a negative situation/object and then immediately disassociates himself from the negative situation/object. For example, in the first debate, Obama countered McCain using an agreement-disassociation tactic. He explained that “Senator McCain is right that often times lobbyists and special interests are the ones that are introducing these [negative] kinds of requests, although that wasn’t the case with me” (Commission, 2008a, p. 7). Obama countered by first agreeing with the negative idea McCain presented – specifically, that lobbyists and special interest groups have power that needs to be curbed – but then disassociating himself from the assertion’s negative connotations. In this way, he presented agreement as an argument in the form of an agreement-disassociation counter-contention. The structure of the agreement-disassociation counter is thus clear. A agrees situation X is bad but A is not associated with X.

We observed a second type of agreement counter-contention: a blame turn. A turn, in debate terminology, occurs when a debater uses an opponent’s statement to his/her own advantage, turning the statement against the one who originally made it (Freeley & Steinberg, 2009). Obama employed this technique, turning McCain’s own evidence and logic against him, during the debates. By using blame turns, Obama did not have to directly refute McCain’s warrants; he was able to simply point the finger of blame back in McCain’s direction.

Obama used the agreement as blame turn tactic several times in the debates, but never so prominently as near the end of the first debate. McCain articulated negative connections between the Bush Administration and the U.S. involvement in Iraq. Moderator Lehrer asked Obama if he saw the same connections McCain had just mentioned. Obama agreed, “Oh, there’s no doubt,” and



then turned his response into an attack on McCain by blaming him and the Republican Party: “look, over the last eight years, this administration, along with Senator McCain, have been solely focused on Iraq” (Commission, 2008a, p. 34).

The basic structure of agreement blame turn is apparent in the above example. A agrees with opponent B’s statement X, yet X reflects poorly on B, not on A. Obama thus successfully turned McCain’s contention into an attack on McCain. In this instance, Obama did not have to provide a direct response to the issue introduced; he merely shifted the negative spotlight on to McCain. By agreeing with McCain’s language and subsequently turning the statement, Obama was able to associate McCain with the unpopular Bush administration, consequently arguing against McCain’s policies on Iraq.

Agreement language also formed a direct rebuttal counter-contention. Previous literature suggests that using agreement as rebuttal is counter-intuitive because the purpose of a rebuttal is to overcome opposing evidence by introducing *other* reasoning that will destroy its effect (Freeley & Steinberg, 2009). We found instances, however, where Obama structures agreement language to successfully rebut statements made by McCain. He does this by agreeing with one of McCain’s conclusions, but pointing out the faulty logic leading to the conclusion. In this way, the audience is made aware of fallacies in McCain’s reasoning.

The most prominent example of agreement as direct rebuttal is demonstrated in the second debate. McCain attempted to discredit Obama’s policy on Iraq by emphasizing Obama’s lack of war experience. McCain concluded that Obama’s lack of experience made it impossible for Obama to understand the nature of the issue and therefore it would be impossible for Obama

to assess the situation and decide on a correct course of action. Theoretically, Obama should have directly negated McCain's assertion by presenting evidence to the contrary. Instead, Obama agrees with McCain, saying, "I don't understand. It's true." (Commission, 2008b, p. 22). He continues, "I don't understand how we invaded a country that had nothing to do with 9/11" (Commission, 2008b, p. 22). He never has to explicitly state McCain's failures in logic behind his support to invade Iraq; it is implied and understood in the technique of the agreement rebuttal presentation. The structure of argument that overcomes the challenge of using agreement as rebuttal becomes, A agrees with B's conclusion X, but B's reasoning for X is faulty. Obama agrees with McCain and in the process, provides the type of counter-argument Freeley and Steinberg (2009) label as necessary for a successful rebuttal.

**Expression of bi-partisanship.** A second form of agreement used in the 2008 debates is bi-partisanship. McCain claimed several times that he was willing to reach across the aisle and rebel against his own party if it meant a successful policy-making compromise could be reached. Obama provided an example of an instance in which he agreed with McCain to provide empirical evidence of successful bi-partisanship on his part. He mentioned "the financial rescue plan that Senator McCain and I supported" (Commission, 2008c, p. 3), indicating he was open to the idea of bi-partisanship and encouraged it with his own actions.

The bi-partisan form follows a structure of compromise and problem-solving. A agrees with B that plan XY was the right solution for both A and B. In this way, both A and B are given positive attributes, and neither party is shown to be superior to the other. Both candidates relied on the form of bi-partisan expression to argue for their abilities to negotiate on a bi-partisan level.

Touting differs from disassociation in that when a speaker employs touting, he/she explicitly highlights his/her own positive attributes instead of simply distancing him/herself from a negative implication made by an opponent. The debater agrees with his/her opponent about a topic and then touts that particular topic to sell his/her position. When used this way, agreement in the form of touting becomes a type of positive argument.

For example, in the first debate, Obama agreed with McCain and then used the agreement to put himself in a positive light by claiming he had done just what McCain said was the right action. He stated, "Senator McCain is absolutely right that the earmarks process has been abused" (Commission, 2008a, p. 7). He then turned this to his advantage by highlighting how his record proves he has not only avoided the negative implications of McCain's claim but also moved against the negative concept. He further explained that is "why I suspended any requests for my home state, whether it was for senior centers or what have you, until we cleaned it up" (Commission, 2008a, p. 7). Obama agreed with McCain that dirty politics should be stopped and then provided evidence that showed he is not the proper target for McCain's complaints and accusations. In fact, Obama used McCain's arguments to his advantage to highlight the positive actions he had taken against the negative occurrences he and McCain agreed existed. Argument as agreement touting takes the form of A agrees with X and X is associated with A. The touting technique thus highlights the positive attributes of the arguer through agreement with the opponent.

### **Discussion**

Of the six types of agreement argument used by the candidates in the debates, the counter-contention blame turn strategy dominated the agreement rhetoric,

though it was used almost exclusively by Senator Obama. Argument counter-contention forms (including all three sub-types) accounted for 50% of the agreement instances by Obama. Overall, Obama used the form of agreement as a counter argument to McCain's assertions more than he used any other agreement argument type.

## **Implications**

The implications of this study are two-fold. First, the findings extend the literature on agreement as argument. New forms and techniques of agreement have been defined and structurally outlined. Three types of agreement as argument in the form of a counter-contention – disassociation, blame turn, and rebuttal – have been articulated. We have also shown that agreement can also be used to demonstrate a form of bi-partisanship. Finally, we have identified the form of agreement as touting.

Second, from a structural standpoint, each of these three agreement forms could be incorporated into a debate outside a political context. All three types of agreement as counter-contention, along with touting, are structurally independent of context. Additionally, bi-partisanship as a form of agreement can have broader application beyond political contexts. The structure integrates both compromise and problem-solving techniques that could be utilized during a wide range of situations ranging from interpersonal relationships or small groups to competitive debates, etc.

## **Limitations**

By parametricizing the study to focus solely on the discourse used during the debates, several areas of influence were not considered. The focus of this study concerned agreement as a form of argument. We used written manuscripts to review occasions of agreement.

We readily concede that nonverbal communication may have played a vital role in the complete portrait of the function of agreement (e.g., facial expressions during agreement, whether agreement is made while looking at the opponent, etc.), but this was outside the parameters of this investigation. This research is limited to discovering the linguistic forms of agreement.

### **Future Research**

The implications of this study build a foundation for future research. A longitudinal study comparing the use of agreement in the 2008 presidential debates with past and future debates would help give further context and potential meaning to forms of agreement. It would be interesting to analyze the political content of agreement such as what issues or policies are repeatedly agreed upon. Likewise, agreement as argument should be studied in non-political debate contexts to determine effects, impacts, and successful strategies.

We believe the most intriguing area for future research is related to Barack Obama's extended use of agreement as opposed to only one use of agreement by John McCain in the debates. Our study observed that, in the presidential debates of 2008, Obama was responsible for 26 statements of agreement, while McCain was responsible for only one such statement. The first debate featured 13 instances of agreement, each one made by Barack Obama. John McCain never explicitly stated he agreed with his opponent on any issue at any time in this debate. This pattern was repeated in the second debate, with Obama again being solely responsible for initiating agreement; McCain never once indicated agreement. The second debate is fascinating in that it contains the fewest episodes of agreement – less than half the number of occurrences found in each of the other two debates. Perhaps this is due to the radically different

format of the second debate, which was conducted using a town hall structure in which audience members were invited to read their questions to the candidates. A precise rationale for this variation may be a fruitful topic for further research. In the third debate, unlike the previous two debates in which Senator Obama was the sole initiator of agreement, Senator McCain expresses agreement on one occasion.

Obama's extensive use of agreement compared to McCain's gives rise to questions of a critical nature. Did the political significance of being the first black presidential nominee contribute to his use of agreement in an attempt to overcome perceived cultural stereotypes? Did the difference in age and experience between Obama and McCain contribute to an increased use of agreement on the part of Obama? What impact did the non-incumbent nature of the election cycle have on the use of agreement? Such questions deserve attention in future research.

Furthermore, it would be interesting to discover if the agreement rhetoric positively impacted the audience's perception of Obama and/or negatively impacted audience perception of McCain. For instance, in the eyes of viewers, did McCain's resistance to agree contradict his own statements that he would reach across the aisle in a bipartisan effort? Now that the results of the election are known, scholars can investigate the impact of agreement in the form of argument.

## References

- Benoit, W. (2007). *Communication in political campaigns*. New York: Peter Lang.
- Benoit, W., & Hansen, G. (2002). Issue adaptation of presidential television spots and debates to primary

- and general audiences. *Communication Research Reports*, 19, 138-145.
- Benoit, W., & Harthcock, A. (1999). Functions of the Great Debates: Acclaims, attacks and defenses in the 1960 presidential debates. *Communication Monographs*, 66, 341-357.
- Benoit, W., Pier, P. M., & Blaney, J. (1997). A functional approach to televised spots: Acclaiming, attacking and defending. *Communication Quarterly*, 45, 1-20.
- Bitzer, L., & Reuter, T. (1980). *Carter vs. Ford: The counterfeit debates of 1976*. Madison, WI: University of Wisconsin Press.
- Brockriede, W. (1975). Where is argument? *Journal of the American Forensics Association*, 11, 179-182.
- Commission on Presidential Debates (2008a). *The first McCain-Obama presidential debate*. Retrieved November 22, 2008 from Commission on Presidential Debates website: [http://www.debates.org/pages/trans2008a\\_p.html](http://www.debates.org/pages/trans2008a_p.html).
- Commission on Presidential Debates (2008b). *The second McCain-Obama presidential debate*. Retrieved November 22, 2008 from Commission on Presidential Debates website: [http://www.debates.org/pages/trans2008c\\_p.html](http://www.debates.org/pages/trans2008c_p.html).
- Commission on Presidential Debates (2008c). *The third McCain-Obama presidential debate*. Retrieved November 22, 2008 from Commission on Presidential Debates website: [http://www.debates.org/pages/trans2008d\\_p.html](http://www.debates.org/pages/trans2008d_p.html).
- Dailey, W., Hink, E., & Hink, S. (2005). Audience perceptions of politeness and advocacy skills in the 2000 and 2004 Presidential debates. *Argumentation and Advocacy*, 41, 196-210.

- Doerfel, M. L., & Connaughton, S. L. (2009). Semantic networks and competition: Election year winners and losers in U.S. televised presidential debates, 1960-2004. *Journal for the American Society for Information Science & Technology*, 60, 201-218.
- Ehninger, D. (1970). Argument as method: Its nature, its limitations and its uses. *Speech Monographs*, 37, 101-110.
- Farah, G. (2004). *No debate: How the Republican and Democratic parties secretly control the presidential debates*. New York: Seven Stories Press.
- Freeley, A. J., & Steinberg, D. L. (2009). *Argumentation and debate: Critical thinking for reasoned decision making*. Belmont, CA: Wadsworth Publishing.
- Goodnight, G. T., Majdik, Z. P., & Kephart, J. M. III. (2009). Presidential debates as public argument. In S. Jacobs & M. Zaresfky (Eds.), *Concerning argument: Selected papers from the 15<sup>th</sup> biennial National Communication Association/American Forensics Association Alta Conference on Argumentation*. Washington, D.C.: National Communication Association.
- Hellweg, S., Pfau, M., & Brydon, S. (1992). *Televised presidential debates: Advocacy in contemporary America*. New York: Praeger.
- Holbert, R., Hansen, G., Mortenson, S., & Caplan, S. (2006). An analysis of relative influences of *Fahrenheit 9/11* and presidential debate viewing on shifting confidence in President Bush. *Communication Research Reports*, 23, 209-216.
- Inch, E. S., Warnick, B., & Endres, D. (2006). *Critical thinking and communication: The use of reason in argument*. Boston: Pearson Education.
- Jamieson, K., & Birdsell, D. (1988) *Presidential debates*.



New York: Oxford.

- Kelley, S. (1960). *Political campaigning: Problems in creating an informed electorate*. Washington, DC: Brookings.
- Kelley, S. (1962). Campaign debates: Some facts and issues. *Politic Opinion Quarterly*, 26, 351-366.
- Kephart III, J. M. (2005). Argumentation and democracy: Towards a model of deliberative debate. *Conference Proceedings - National Communication Association/ American Forensics Association (Alta Conference on Argumentation)*, 380 – 385.
- Lang, G. (1987). Still seeking answers. *Critical Studies in Mass Media Studies*, 4, 211-215.
- Lanoue, D. J., & Schrott, P. R. (1991). *The joint press conference: The history, impact, and prospects of American presidential debate*. New York: Greenwood Press.
- McKinney, M. S., & Carlin, D. B. (2004). Political campaign debates. In L. L. Kaid (Ed.), *Handbook of political communication research* (pp. 203-336). Mahwah, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum.
- Moore, B. N., & Parker, R. (2004). *Critical thinking*. New York: McGraw-Hill.
- Pfau, M. (2002). The subtle nature of presidential debate influence. *Argumentation and Advocacy*, 38, 251-261.
- Pfau, M., & Diedrich, T. (1993). Relational and competence perceptions of presidential candidates during primary election. *Journal of Broadcasting & Electronic Media*, 37, 275-293.
- Poggi, I., D'Errico, F., & Vincze, L. (2011). Agreement and its multimodal communication in debates: A qualitative analysis. *Cognitive Computation*, 3, 466 -

479.

Vancil, D., & Pendell, S. (1984). Winning Presidential debates: An analysis of criteria influencing audience response. *The Western Journal of Speech Communication*, 48, 62-74.

Ziegelmüller, G. W., & Kay, J. (1997) *Argumentation: Inquiry & advocacy*. Needham Heights, MA: Allyn & Bacon.

***Sara K. Straub is a Ph.D. candidate in communication at the University of Oklahoma. Jeremie L. Beller is a Ph.D. candidate in communication at the University of Oklahoma. Tim W. Hunt was a graduate student in communication at the University of Oklahoma at the time this study was conducted. Correspondence should be addressed to Sara K. Straub at sk\_straub@ou.edu.***